



Relief sculptures in Egyptian tombs represented everyday life and religious rituals. This carving from the Sixth dynasty shows boys with sticks, on the left, and youths wrestling, on the right.

the authority of the Egyptian rulers had steadily eroded.

In **Western Europe**, the **Bell Beaker culture** flourished. Named after the distinctive shape of **pottery vessels** found in graves, this culture emerged by c. 2600 BCE in France, Spain, and the Netherlands. Over the next three centuries, it spread to Germany and Britain. Around 2300 BCE, **bronze technology** from Mediterranean regions and from Central Europe started to **spread** northward **along the Rhine and Danube**. The increasingly militaristic societies used bronze to create weapons, triggering the appearance of **small chiefdoms** across Europe.

As populations grew, **competition over land and resources** intensified. Fields were enclosed, farming expanded, and boundary walls built. Imposing structures such as **chalk mounds** were constructed in many areas.

In **South America**, societies continued to develop in two distinct regions: the upland **valleys** and **high plains** of the **Andes**,

and along the **Pacific coast** and inland valleys. Andean cultures were based on **farming** and **herding**. **Coastal settlements** such as Aspero (Peru) were unique in their dependence on **fishing** rather than on agriculture. The coastal people grew cotton for textiles, and gourds, which were used as fishing floats.

THE MOUNTAIN PEOPLE OF GUTIUM ATTACKED the Akkadian Empire c. 2150 BCE. **Sumerian states** such as Kish, Ur, and Lagash took the opportunity to **reassert their independence**. For the next 80 years, the city-states vied for control in Mesopotamia. In 2112 BCE, **Ur** under Ur-Nammu (r. 2112–2095 BCE) gained ascendancy. The armies of Ur overran eastern Mesopotamia and Elam, and regained much of Sargon's empire.

Ur-Nammu founded the **Third dynasty of Ur**, which witnessed a **revival of Sumerian power**, as well as an artistic and cultural **renaissance**. Sumerian scholars devised a method of counting, based on units of 60. This system is reflected in our modern division of hours into 60 minutes, minutes into 60 seconds, and a circle into 360 degrees.

Ur-Nammu also commissioned the **first ziggurat** in Ur—an imposing stepped platform topped with a temple. The ziggurats later became a characteristic of ancient western Asian architecture.

In c. 2181 BCE, Egypt's **Old Kingdom collapsed** following a series of natural disasters, including famine. This undermined the authority of the king, who was believed to secure the annual floods that

brought fertility to the Nile valley. The rule of Memphis, the capital city of the Old Kingdom, was overthrown as nomarchs and nobles seized control of the provinces. This ushered in a time of **unrest** called the **First Intermediate Period**, the first of the three eras of uncertainty in Egyptian history. For 140 years, kingdoms such as Herakleopolis in central Egypt vied for control with Thebes in the south. In c. 2040 BCE, the Theban ruler Nebhepetre **Mentuhotep** defeated his rivals and **united Egypt** once more, beginning the start of what came to be known as the **Middle Kingdom**.

In China, the Neolithic **Longshan culture** (see 3200 BCE) continued to develop along the Yellow River in Shandong province. According to Chinese historical tradition, the **first dynasty, Xia (Hsia)**, was **founded** by Yu the Great. However, **no archaeological evidence** has

Longshan pottery

This elegant pottery tripod pitcher has tapering legs and swirling patterns, characteristic of the Longshan culture.



been found to confirm the existence of a **centralized state** in China at this time.

By the end of the 3rd millennium, **Europe's first civilization** was emerging on the Mediterranean island of **Crete**, which lay at the heart of Mediterranean trade routes. Known as the **Minoan civilization**, it grew prosperous through **trade and farming**. Cretan farmlands produced wheat, olives, wine, and wool, which could be easily transported by sea. The Minoans also made bronzework, pottery, and dyes for export. By 2000 BCE, Crete was home to several small kingdoms.

100 THOUSAND THE LIKELY POPULATION OF UR c.2100

Akkadian warrior king

This bronze cast of an Akkadian ruler may depict Sargon I or his grandson, Naram-Sin, who extended Sargon's empire.



c. 2300 BCE Bronze Age begins in southern Europe, in Italy and the Balkans

2278–2184 BCE Reign of Pepy II of the Sixth dynasty in Egypt

c. 2205 BCE Xia dynasty founded in eastern China by Yu the Great, according to Chinese tradition; said to have ruled until 1766

c. 2150 BCE Gutians defeat Akkadians; city-states of Mesopotamia, such as Lagash, reassert independence

2112–2095 BCE Reign of Ur-Nammu of Ur reunites much of Mesopotamia; rebuilds Ur's temple as a ziggurat

c. 2150 BCE Nubian kingdom emerges south of Egypt, based at Kerma on Third Cataract of Nile

2112 BCE Third Dynasty of Ur, founded by Ur-Nammu (to 2040 BCE)

c. 2040 BCE Nebhepetre Mentuhotep of Thebes defeats rivals to unite Egypt

2004 BCE City of Ur falls to Elamites, ending dynasty of Ur